

Product test

Oil changes with less mess

If you've ever considered changing your car's oil yourself but were put off by the mess, you might consider buying an oil extractor, such as those sold by Overton's (Item No. 26696, \$70; 800 334-6541; www.overton.com) or by Griot's Garage (Item No. 10122, \$78; 800 345-5789; www.griotsgarage.com). Prices include shipping.

An oil extractor is a plastic cylinder with a pump at the top and a hose at one end that draws oil up from the oil pan through a car's dipstick tube—a far easier process than shimmying under the car. Setup is simple:

Remove your car's dipstick from the dipstick tube and insert the oil-extractor hose down the hole until it reaches the bottom of the oil pan. Pump the handle of the oil extractor to create a vacuum (it took us only five to ten pumps), and oil is drawn into the cylinder. It holds nearly 7 quarts, or 6.5 liters. The process took us about ten minutes.

You can carry the used oil to your local collection center in the cylinder; there's no need to transfer it to another container.

(Most gas stations and some oil-change facilities also accept used oil.)

We had good results using the oil extractor on seven different vehicles plus a 5-liter marine engine. But it doesn't work for all cars, especially those with a narrow dipstick tube, like the *Honda S2000* and the *Pontiac Grand Prix* 3.8-liter V6 we tested. (The oil extractor includes two hoses that measure $\frac{1}{4}$ and $\frac{3}{8}$ inch in diameter.) Nor will the extractor work well if your vehicle has two drain plugs or an internal dipstick guide that won't let the hose into the crank case.

A smaller extractor, Overton's Item No. 27266, costs \$48. But it required excessive pumping.



Travel

Can you

trust your travel agent?

When you telephone a travel agent and ask for all nonstop flights available on a certain day at the cheapest fare, that's what you get, right?

Not necessarily, according to Consumer Reports Travel Letter, which asked 840 travel agents about airline fares for 12 of the most popular U.S. routes for leisure travelers. There is intense competition along these routes, and in most cases two or more carriers offer the same low fare. Yet only 51 percent of travel agents disclosed all low-fare flights when the Travel Letter's anonymous callers first asked for them; another 12 percent revealed all low-fare carriers when the caller repeated the question. Twenty-five percent of the travel agents never disclosed all the cheap flights. And 12 percent erroneously presented a higher-priced fare as the cheapest. (We know this because at the same time we called the travel agents, a con-

sultant checked a computer-reservation system that listed all available flights and fares.)

Why does it matter that so many agents omitted competing airlines with the same airfare? Because it violates the principle of full disclosure. And it doesn't allow consumers the full opportunity to choose an airline based on their experience, frequent-flyer benefits, and beliefs about safety.

It's impossible to determine whether the agents' poor showing resulted from lack of training, inadequate technology, or intentional bias. Major airlines and other travel enterprises such as cruise lines, hotels, tour operators, and car-rental companies pay travel agencies bonuses (or "overrides," in industry parlance) to steer customers their way. This practice is especially troubling because now nearly all travel agencies are charging their customers service fees—ostensibly for impartial information.



Playing 'fare'?

AIRLINE ROUTE	AGENCIES CALLED	DISCLOSED LOWEST FARES?			
		ALL, IMMEDIATELY	ALL, AFTER 2ND REQUEST	SOME, AFTER 2ND REQUEST	NONE, AFTER 2ND REQUEST
Atlanta-New Orleans	69	58%	26%	13%	3%
Boston-Washington	55	51	0	7	42
Chicago-Santa Ana	100	54	23	23	0
Dallas-Fort Lauderdale	57	88	5	4	4
Denver-Los Angeles	70	30	4	61	4
Detroit-Tampa	97	80	4	1	16
Kansas City-Phoenix	34	77	2	0	21
Los Angeles-Las Vegas	79	17	13	70	0
Minneapolis-Orlando	57	58	10	28	4
New York-West Palm Beach	116	60	8	2	30
Raleigh/Durham-New York	59	32	27	37	3
Washington-Fort Lauderdale	47	0	0	72	28
RESULTS	840	51%	12%	25%	12%